PASS Summit West 2026

Home on the Columbia River

What it’s like to live on a floating home on the Columbia and why I love it

Kellyn Gorman · Portland, Oregon

Portland: America’s floating-home capital

1,050

floating homes in Portland itself

1,500+

across the Portland metro area, Gresham to St. Helens

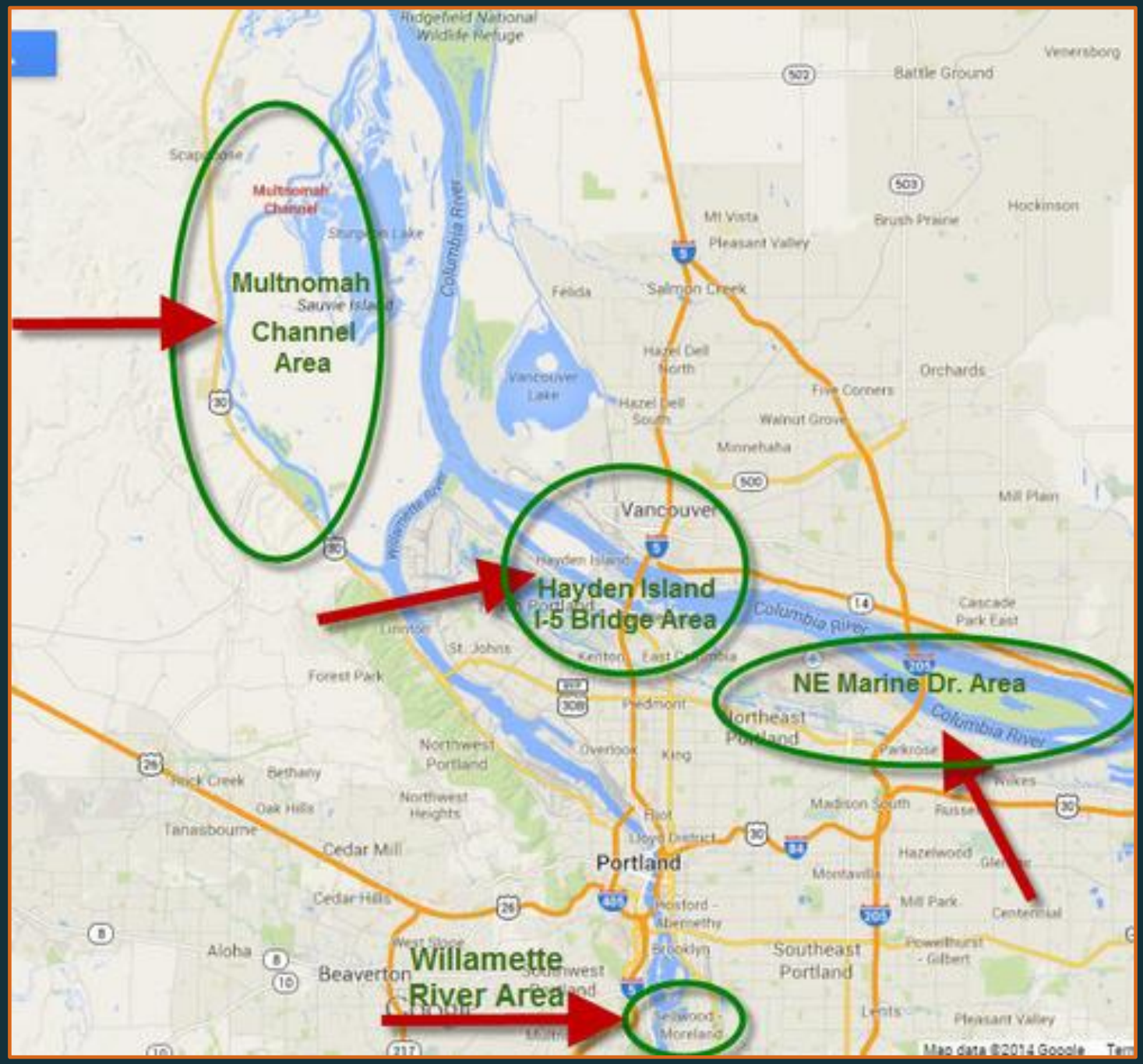
More than anywhere else in the U.S.

More than Seattle’s Lake Union or Sausalito, California

Dozens of moorages

Along the Columbia, Multnomah Channel, North Portland Harbor and the Willamette

The Portland Area



My Neighborhood/My Home





My home on the Columbia

6+

years

living on the river year-round

2

stories

a full house, but it just happens to float

30+ ft

of water below

about 10 meters between my floats and the riverbed

Not All Moors/Slips are Alike

- Finger slips/straight slips
- Slip ownership/rental
- HOA/self-managed
- Easement vs. “mud ownership”





A floating home is not a houseboat

	Floating home	Houseboat
Engine	None, it stays put	Yes, it can cruise
Utilities	City water, sewer, power	Tanks and batteries
Where it lives	A permanent slip in a moorage	Anywhere it can dock
Foundation	A float of logs or concrete and foam	A boat hull

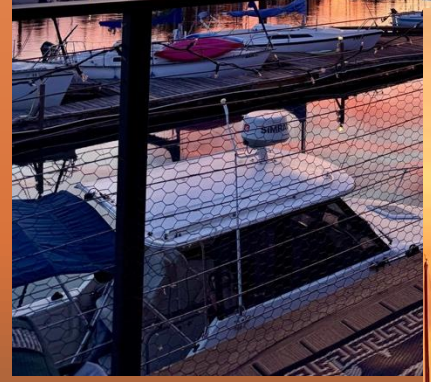




EVERY SINGLE DAY

I wake up to the river.







Mist lifting off the water, tidal rise and fall, sunrise and sunset over the Columbia, and a view that is never the same twice.

The best show in town: people and boats

Working river

Tug boats and marinas busy bringing supplies up and down the river.

Weekend boaters

Sailboats, ski boats, party barges and yachts

Paddlers

Kayaks, rowers and paddleboarders gliding past the deck. We have about 4 or 5 hydrofoils, too

Dock neighbors

A tight community, i.e. “river life” you end up with a very close-knit community of neighbors

Neighbors with fur, flippers and feathers

Sea lions

Loud, curious and fond of barking at night. They come upstream for the salmon. You hear them blow air when they break the surface!

River otters

Playful visitors who love to explore the docks, munch on fish, but you never want them to live under your house!

Beavers

Busy swimmers, most often seen at dusk and munch on all the river offers. They are gentle and get quite large!

Water birds

Herons, ducks, geese, cormorants, eagles and especially osprey. There are winged battles for fish that would put top gun to shame and spring brings tons of ducklings and goslings!

Our Home Maintenance is Not Like Yours

What	What it involves	How often
The float	Check logs or foam, re-level with ballast	Every few years
Cables & stiff-arms	Inspect the lines that hold the house in its slip	Yearly
Siding & decks	Moss and mildew removal, sanding and staining	Seasonally
Spiders	Sweep websthe, river is spider heaven, but no mosquitos!	Constantly
Debris & storms	Push off floating logs after high water	After storms
Utility lines, water pipes	Keep flexible hookups healthy as the river rises and falls	Yearly
Walls, counters, doors and windows	Cleaning and caulking to seal cracks	Every few months
Dredging	Removal of sediment and sand that some moors are impacted by.	Every 10 years
Replacement of docks/gangways	Replace stringers and surface boards	Every 25 years, 5-year maintenance

Things you'd never guess

Furniture is ballast

Redecorate, construction projects and the house can tilt

Drop it, lose it

Keys, phones, tools, drop them and 30 feet down they go and gone. Neighbor has a magnet on a fishing pole to retrieve some items.

The house moves

You can't feel it, but it does move slightly. Only twice I've felt it move in 6 years.

The ramp changes

High water, flat walk; low water, steep climb up the ramp…especially late summer

Groceries by cart

I threaten to put in a zip line a couple times per year.

Floods? We rise

The house simply floats up with the river. We've tracked the high-water years on the pilons.

What if I want to move my home?

Yes, you can, but it takes professionals and 1-3 tugboats…☺

It’s quite expensive to do, but it’s really fun to watch!



WHY I LOVE IT

Sometimes, it’s like being on vacation, every day in my own home.

Nature

Wildlife and water right outside the window

Community

Neighbors who truly know each other

Calm

The river slows life down

Questions?

Ask me anything about life on the water and no question is too odd.

Thank you , Kellyn Gorman